neatly divided time-consumingritual duties (ceremonially important but politically pointless) from the equally time-consuming duties of actual governance. The sovereign on the throne took care of the first; the ruler in the monastery, the second. It also preserved an appearance of cooperation between the emperor-in-name and his Fujiwara advisor, while the actual power struggle between king and Fujiwara clan went on, more or less, in private.

But the Cloistered Emperor system also, inevitably, multiplied the battles for power within the royal family itself.

WHEN THE THREE-YEAR-OLD Emperor Konoe was crowned in 1142, the imperial household was already filled with crackling hostilities.

Those hostilities had unfolded over three generations. Back in 1107, the emperor of Japan had been four-year-old Toba; the Cloistered Emperor, wielding the real power from the traditional monastery, was Toba's imperious and long-lived grandfather Shirakawa. When Toba reached his teens, Shirakawa arranged for him to marry the beautiful teenaged Shoshi—his own adopted ward. Court gossip said that Shoshi was much more than Shirakawa's ward. When Shoshi gave birth to a son and heir in 1119, the baby was generally assumed to be Shirakawa's, even though Toba claimed the child as his own.[6]

The rumors got an imperial stamp of approval in 1123, when Shirakawa forced Toba to abdicate in favor of the four-year-old boy, who now became Emperor Sutoku. This relegated Toba, still just twenty-three, to a completely powerless position; he was now a Cloistered Emperor, but he was junior to his vigorous grandfather and inferior to his crowned son. Toba simmered in impotent resentment until Shirakawa finally died in 1129.

Once able to assume the real power of a Cloistered Emperor, Toba allowed his son-in-name to stay on the throne. But in 1139, Toba's favorite wife, Tokuko, finally gave birth to a son—Konoe, his *actual* flesh and blood. Three years later, Toba forced Sutoku to abdicate in Konoe's favor—just as he himself had been forced to abdicate in Sutoku's favor, twenty years before.

